As she traveled, Davis began writing her own long-form narrative, later published as *Angela Davis: An Autobiography*, which was edited by Toni Morrison and published by Random House in 1974. The book was an attempt to produce a "political autobiography," as Davis notes in the preface, to "emphasize the people, the events and the forces in my life [that] propelled me to my present commitment."[9] Writing in the two years after her acquittal, Davis used the platform to transition from her position as a philosopher writing from prison while facing the death penalty to the role of liberated author and narrative autobiographer who devoted much of her life's work to freedom movements and critical prison activism. Under Morrison's editorial guidance, Davis was compelled to adapt her writing style. As she recalled later, "When I wrote my autobiography I was somebody who was used to writing philosophy, and so I didn't think about writing in the same way. Rather than, like, writing it for me, Toni would say, 'Well, you know, what was that room like, you know, what did it look like? What was in there? What were the colors?' And so she made me understand writing in such a different way."[10] This move, to focus on her own narrative, allowed Davis to fuse her theoretical writings with the craft of literary production and autobiography. At the time of the autobiography's writing, as one of America's most prominent figures seeking the power of telling her own story, she faced several key challenges: how to present her own personal travails for readers while demonstrating her political commitments; how to represent the barriers she faced in her life as repressive in their own right while simultaneously showing how they served as platforms for solidarity and critical engagement; and how to shape the contours of her own travels for popular readership.

Davis sought this balance by adopting walls as her autobiography's most powerful and pertinent literary symbol. She wrote about walls that divide, walls that call connections into recognition, walls that mark the boundary between freedom and repression, and walls that when toppled lead to new pathways for freedom. The book includes a dedication directed to "those whose humanity is too rare to be destroyed by walls, bars, and death houses"; descriptions of numerous prison walls and other forms of social/physical architecture; and a chapter titled "Walls." The book's closing section, labeled "Bridges," includes this epigraph: "Walls turned sideways are bridges."[11]